

A sight to behold

The locals found the steam locomotive, stationed in a grove of toddy trees. fascinating. The *Bombay Telegraph* of 17 February 1852 reported: "The native population appears to evince great interest in the 'Fire Chariot' as they name her, and crowd round to have a look. The weight and massive character of the whole is quite at variance with their notion of speed; and after observing the slow progress she made when being dragged along the public road by 200 coolies their incredulous look of astonishment is not to be wondered at when told, that in a few days she will be able to pass the race course swifter than their fleetest Arabs."

In action

The first trial run on 18 February 1852 was from the Byculla to Parel stations. The second run occurred eight months later on 18 November from start to finish. The locals saw the train as a giant monster, whistling and throwing steam, generating many emotions. Some called it *lokhandi rakshash*, or iron demon in Marathi, an evil entity that drew its power from young people who had been buried under its tracks. Others saw it as a means employed by the British to flee after taking their lands and money. The rest were just confused about this miracle.

History in the making

A year later, on 16 April 1853, the first passenger train finally made its maiden run from Bori Bunder station to Thana, a distance of 33 km. The day, according to *Bombay Times*, "was observed as a public holiday".

The train comprised 14 railway carriages hauled by three locomotives named *Sahib*, *Sindh*, and *Sultan*. Although their presence has been recorded, there is photographic evidence of only one locomotive as taken by Jamsetjee Jeejeebhoy, an Indian merchant and philanthropist. There are theories that suggest that the other two were back-ups. Nevertheless, the train carrying more than 400 passengers, left Bori Bunder, with a 21-gun salute, at 3.30pm and reached Thana at 4.45pm. According to *The Illustrated London News*, there was a massive crowd waiting to witness the arrival of the train. The trip back